

A working framework, not a decided plan

Six pathways to a civic, regenerative food system

The ambition is simple to state and hard to do: move London's collective buying power behind organic and regenerative farms, make nutrient density — not calories — the target, and build a food system that is more resistant to shocks and more civic-led and owned. There is no single plan that delivers all of that at once. There are several distinct levers, each with a different starting point, a different pace, and a different failure mode. This page sets them out side by side.

[See the six pathways](#)[Back to the portfolio](#)

Stated once, so every pathway can be tested against it

Four things the system has to do at once

Each pathway below is a different route toward all four of these — none of them get there alone.

Buying power

Collective, not fragmented

London's institutional demand — councils, schools, health services, markets — moves as a coalition large enough to change a farmer's decision, not as 33 separate pilots.

Nutrient density

The target, not calories

What gets grown, bought and served is measured against what actually nourishes people, not against volume or cost alone.

Resilience

A system that absorbs shocks

Organic and regenerative soils hold more water and need fewer imported inputs — a food system built on them is measurably steadier under stress, not just greener.

Civic ownership

Held by the community, not the market

Whatever gets built — a hub, a farm relationship, a buying engine — stays governed by the people who depend on it, structurally protected from resale to speculative capital.

Six entry points, one destination

The six pathways

Each is a different lever to pull first. The portfolio already has real traction on two of them — see [where we are](#) below — but it is worth being explicit that they are separable strategies, not one sequence everyone has already agreed to.

01 Demand-first — aggregate the buying power

● Demand lever

Institutional procurement: councils, schools, NHS, markets

Start by getting London's institutional buyers into a shared procurement charter or buying coalition, using guaranteed collective volume as the credibility signal that pulls supply into being. This is the fastest way to show boroughs moving together.

Tradeoff: demand without patient capital on the supply side just reshuffles existing organic supply between buyers rather than growing it — needs Pathway 02 running alongside it, or the gains plateau fast.

Connects to: [the Procurement Charter and Collective Buying Engine](#)

02 Supply-first — de-risk the conversion ● Supply lever

Farmer and grower transition finance

Lead with the money that gets land converted: bridge financing for the multi-year “J-curve” income dip that organic and regenerative conversion causes, sponsored or underwritten farmland, and blended capital vehicles. This is what actually grows the acreage — and the resilience benefit that comes with it.

Tradeoff: farms that convert into a market that isn’t guaranteed yet are carrying the risk alone. This only works safely tied tightly to a demand commitment, or with the coalition itself underwriting the loan.

Connects to: [sponsored/underwritten farmland and organic-transition bridge financing](#)

03 Infrastructure-first — build the connective hubs ● Hub lever

Logistics, storage and aggregation capacity

Prioritise the physical capacity — hub-and-spoke sites, cold storage, forecasting — that lets many small regenerative producers reach many institutional buyers reliably. This solves the structural problem that no single small farm can meet one large council contract alone, and it is the connective tissue Pathways 01 and 02 both depend on.

Tradeoff: infrastructure without either a committed buyer base or a growing supply base is expensive capacity sitting idle — sequencing matters more here than anywhere else.

Connects to: [the London Hubs & Markets Working Group, Camden food hub\(s\)](#)

04 Ownership-first — lock in civic control before scaling ● Civic muscle

Governance and asset structure

Build the governance structure — distributed, two-key style ownership, where local stewardship and a wider civic body both have to agree before an asset can be sold — before or alongside the first hub or contract, so nothing that later succeeds commercially becomes acquirable by speculative capital.

Tradeoff: getting governance right first can slow momentum when the urgent thing people want to see is a working pilot. There is a real risk of over-designing the lock before there is anything worth locking.

Connects to: [Distributed Governance and De-risked Transitional Ownership](#)

05 Policy-first — change the national operating environment

● Civic muscle

National regulation and funding rules

Use London's own evidence base to push for procurement rule changes, funding eligibility and deregulation that make every pathway above cheaper and legal to do at scale — the Tier 3 lever the wider portfolio is already timing to the Civil Contingencies Act review.

Tradeoff: national policy moves on its own clock. A policy-first sequence risks nothing changing on the ground while the centre catches up.

Connects to: [the Local Food Resilience Committee first move](#)

06 Culture-first — redefine what “good” means ● Demand lever

Public demand and measurement

Start by shifting the measure itself: nutrition and supply-gap mapping, a marketing investment fund, consumption transparency — making nutrient density, not calories, the explicit standard institutions procure against. This

builds a durable, values-based mandate that outlives any one contract or administration.

Tradeoff: changing what people measure and want doesn't by itself move a single tonne of food — it needs one of the harder infrastructural pathways to cash it in.

Connects to: [the Nutrition Supply Map and Cascade Model](#)

Read honestly, not aspirationally

Where we already have traction — and where the gap is

None of these pathways are mutually exclusive, and the portfolio is already running more than one at once. Being explicit about which ones are moving and which are lagging is more useful than treating all six as equally live.

Pathway	Where it's already moving	What's still missing
01 Demand	Procurement charter conversations underway; several boroughs aligning on collective buying	A binding collective commitment across the founding boroughs
02 Supply	Named as an instrument in the Sovereign Food System catalogue	A funded, working bridge-financing vehicle — the most exposed gap right now
03 Infrastructure	The London Hubs & Markets Working Group; Regis Road anchor site in progress	Cold-chain and forecasting capacity at full scale
04 Ownership	Distributed Governance model drafted on the main portfolio	Not yet tested against a real, live asset
05 Policy	Local Food Resilience Committee response to the Civil Contingencies Act review	A dedicated London-wide policy ask beyond the resilience committee

The honest read: demand (01) and infrastructure (03) are moving fastest. That makes supply-side transition finance (02) the clearest current gap — the coalition is building buying power and logistics faster than it is de-risking the farms meant to fill them. Ownership (04) is the pathway most easily deferred until “later,” but it is also the hardest to retrofit once a hub is already profitable and attractive to buy.

Already live

The tools these pathways draw on

Each pathway above connects to work that already exists and is public. Worth opening alongside this page.

Pathways 01 & 03

Hubs and Markets Working Group

Where the demand and infrastructure pathways are already being tested against real boroughs, leases and funding gaps.

Pathway 02

A Sovereign Food System

Economic and monetary instruments for redesigning food-system finance, including transition bridge financing and de-risked ownership.

Pathways 04 & 05

Governance, on the main portfolio

The Distributed Governance and three-tier (Borough / London / Policy) model these two pathways are built on.

Pathway 06

Nutrition Supply Map

Where the food actually comes from, and the case for treating nutrient density as the target.

All pathways

Where's the Energy?

What was actually raised by name, and by whom, at the Camden Future Food Dinner and Workshop — the ground-level read this page synthesises upward from.

The whole portfolio

Food as Infrastructure

The main portfolio site these six pathways sit underneath.

If you're weighing where to start

These pathways are a diagnostic, not a queue

The point of setting them out separately is to make it possible to ask, honestly, which lever a given piece of work is actually pulling — and which of the other five it is quietly assuming someone else is handling. If you think the sequencing above is wrong, or a pathway is missing, say so.

[Open the portfolio](#)

[Contact Dark Matter Labs ↗](#)

Six Pathways to a Civic Food System

A Dark Matter Labs working framework, developed from the portfolio's existing tracks, tiers and instruments.

Full portfolio site

Hubs & Markets Working Group

Contact Dark Matter Labs ↗

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